Am I Blue?

By Bruce Coville

VINCENT: **(Pg 1-18)** It started the day Butch Carrigan decided I was interested in *him.*

BUTCH: *(snarling)* You little fruit. I'll teach you to look at me!

VINCENT: A moment or two later he had given me my lesson. I was still lying face down in the puddle into which Butch had slammed me as the culminating exercise of my learning experience when I heard a clear voice exclaim . . .

MELVIN: Oh, my dear! That was nasty. Are you all right, Vince?

VINCENT: *(suspiciously)* Who are you?

MELVIN: Your fairy godfather -- Melvin. Come on, stand up and let's see if we can't do something with you. *(helping Vincent to his feet)*

VINCENT: Are you making fun of me?

MELVIN: Moi? *(arching his eyebrows and laying a hand on his chest)* Listen, honey, I have nothing but sympathy for you. I had to deal with my share of troglodytes when I was your age, and I know it's no fun. I'm here to help. You know, like in 'Cinderella'? Do you want your three wishes or not, Vincent? *(he stalks off)*

INTRODUCTION

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VINCENT: *(catching up, embarrassed)* Do you have to walk like that?

MELVIN: Like what?

VINCENT: *(blushing)* You know . . . So swishy.

MELVIN: Honey, I gave my life to be able to walk like this. Don't you dare try to stop me now. *(proudly)* I walk and talk the way I do because I'm not going to let anyone else define me.

VINCENT: *(to audience)* We went to a little cafe on Morton Street called Pete's and found a table where we could talk in private. I kept trying to figure out what this was really about—-

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Candid Camera, an elaborate practical joke, that kind of thing. *(To Melvin as he takes a sip of coffee; he's shocked that it changed from plain coffee to Swiss double mocha; they both continue to sip during the conversation)* Okay, if you're real, then tell me how come I never heard of fairy godfathers before.

MELVIN: Because I'm the first. It was pretty much expected that I would just opt to be an angel; tracking system, you know. But I said I didn't want to be anyone's guardian angel, I wanted to be a fairy godfather. *(rolls his eyes)* Let me tell you, that caused a hullabaloo! But I said people had been calling me a fairy all my life, and now that I was dead, that was what I wanted to be. You're my first case.

VINCENT: *(nervously)* Does that mean I'm gay? *(to audience)* I didn't mention that I had been trying to figure out the same thing myself for about a year now.

MELVIN: You may be, you may not. The point is, you're getting picked on because people **think** you are—which is why I've been sent to work with you. Gay-bashing is a special issue for me. It's how I met my maker, so to speak. I was walking down the street last year, minding my own business, when three bruisers dragged me into an alley, shouting, 'We'll teach you!' They never did explain exactly what it was they were going to teach me. Last thing I remember was coming face to face with a tire iron. Next thing I knew, I was knocking at the Pearly Gates. *(a silent moment, then Melvin shrugs)*

VINCENT: *(stunned)* You're taking this awfully casually.

MELVIN: Honey, I did a lot of screaming and shouting while it was happening. Afterwards too, for that matter. Didn't do me a bit of good—I was still dead. Once you've been on the other side for a while, you get a little more zen about this kind of thing. Why don't we just concentrate on your case for the time being?

VINCENT: Okay, do I really get three wishes?

MELVIN: Sure do. Well, two, now -- You used up the first one on that coffee.

VINCENT: I didn't tell you to change it into Swiss double mocha!

MELVIN: You didn't have to. You wished for it.

VINCENT: *(muttering)* I'm glad I didn't wish I was dead!

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MELVIN: Oh! Getting personal, are we? *(glances around the room, then winks at a student)*

VINCENT: *(hissing)* Will you stop that!

MELVIN: What's the matter? *(waves his hand)* I guarantee you he wasn't offended. He's one of the gang.

VINCENT: What gang? *(Melvin purses his lips and raises his eyebrows)* How can you tell something like that just from looking at him?

MELVIN: Gaydar -- Automatic sensing systems that lets you spot people of similar persuasion. A lot of gay guys have it to some degree or other. If it was more reliable, it would life easier on us. If a guy asks a girl for a date, about the worst that can happen is that she laughs at him. If he asks another guy, he might get his face pounded in.

VINCENT: *(sadly)* It must be lonely.

MELVIN: *(sharply)* It doesn't have to be. If gay people could just openly identify ourselves, there would be plenty of people you could ask for advice. Everybody knows gay people; they just think they don't. Do you know the great gay fantasy? *(Vincent shakes his head)* Imagine what it would be like if every gay person in the country turned blue for a day. All the straights would have to stop imagining that they didn't know any gay people. They'd have to face the fact that there are gay cops and gay farmers, gay teachers and gay soldiers, gay parents and gay kids. The hiding would finally have to stop. *(beat)* How would you like to have the sight? You might find it interesting.

VINCENT: *(suspiciously)* Does this count as a wish?

MELVIN: No, it's education. Comes under a different category. Close your eyes. *(Martin waves his hands with a flourish)* Okay, open up and see what the world is really like.

VINCENT: *(opens his eyes and gasps) (to audience)* About a third of the people in the café were blue. Some were bright blue, some were deep blue, some just had bluish tint. *(to Martin in a whisper)* Are you telling all those people are gay?

MELVIN: To some degree or other.

VINCENT: But so many of them?

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MELVIN: Well, this isn't a typical place. The theater crowd hangs around in here. *(waves his hand grandly)* Groups like that tend to have a higher percentage of gay people, because we're naturally artistic. *(frowning)* Of course, some bozos take a fact like that and decide that everyone doing theater is gay. Remember, two thirds of the people you're seeing **aren't** blue.

VINCENT: What about all the different shades?

MELVIN: It's an indicator of degree. The lighter ones are less committed—or maybe like you, trying to make up their minds. Come on, let's go for a walk.

VINCENT: *(to audience)* It was like seeing the world through new eyes. Most of the people looked just the same as always, of course. But Mr. Alwain, the guy who ran the grocery store, looked like a giant blueberry—which surprised me, because he was married and had three kids. On the other hand, Ms. Thorndyke, the librarian, who everyone knew was a lesbian, didn't have a trace of blue on her.

MELVIN: Can't tell without the spell. Straights are helpless at it. They're always assuming someone is or isn't for all the wrongs reasons.

VINCENT: *(beat – to audience)* All right, I suppose you're wondering about me—as in, was I blue? The answer is, slightly. When I asked Melvin to explain, he said,

MELVIN: "The Magic Eight Ball says, 'Signs Are Mixed.'" In other words, you are one confused puppy. That's the way it is sometimes. You'll figure it out after a while. *(Melvin disappears)*

VINCENT: *(to audience)* Watching the news that night was a riot. My favorite network anchor was the shade of a spring sky. So was the congressman he interviewed, who happened to be a notorious Republican homophobe. *(beat)* I couldn't forget his hypocritical words: "the great crime of homosexuality" and "the gay threat to American youth." I was brushing my teeth when I figured out what I wanted to do. . . it would probably mean another beating from Butch Carrigan. Yet if I did it, **nothing** would ever be the same. *(whispering)* Melvin?

MELVIN: At your service! Ooooh, what a tacky bathroom.

VINCENT: I want to make my second wish. . . . Gay fantasy coast to coast.

MELVIN: *(a beat then he smiles)* How's midnight for a starting point?

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VINCENT: Twenty-four hours should do the trick, don't you think?

MELVIN: *(rubs his hands, chuckles and disappears)*

VINCENT: *(to audience)* I went to bed, but not to sleep. I kept thinking about what it would mean when the rest of the world could see what I could see today. I turned on the radio. It was about twelve thirty when, thanks to the wonders of modern communication, it had become obvious that people were turning blue from coast to coast. It didn't take much longer for people to start figuring out what the blue stood for. The reaction ranged from panic to hysterical denial to dancing in the streets. National Public Radio quickly summoned a panel of experts to discuss what was going to happen when people had to go to work the next day . . . or school! Which was when I got my next idea. *(shouting)* Melvin!

MELVIN: You rang?

VINCENT: I just figured out my third wish. *(taking a deep breath)* I want you to turn Butch Carrigan blue.

MELVIN: *(eyes wide)* Vincent, I like the way you think. I'll be back in a flash. *(he disappears and pops back in grinning)* You've still got one wish left, kiddo. *(chuckling)* Butch Carrigan was already blue as a summer sky when I got there. *(he disappears)*

VINCENT: *(beat, then to audience)* So . . . if I caused you any trouble with Blueday, I'm sorry. But not much. Because things are never going to be the same now that it happened. Never. And my third wish? I've decided to save it for when I really need it—maybe when I meet the girl of my dreams. Or Prince Charming. Whichever.

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